

CRESCENT ACADEMY, BOOK 1



THE SHATTERED TWIN

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Chapter 1: The Cat

Kai Yusuf always thought his cat was smarter than most people.

Not in the way cats are usually smart—the kind of smartness that lets them knock things off tables while they look you in the eyes. Or the supervillain smartness to wake you up at exactly 4:47 AM for no reason. No, Ash was different. He was the kind of smart that made you wonder if he was secretly judging your homework answers, or silently fixing your grammar when you talked to yourself.

"Stop staring at me like that," Kai muttered, not looking up from his book.

Ash, a sleek ash-grey cat with creepy green eyes, sat on the windowsill with his tail wrapped around his paws. He did not stop staring. The cat smelled like dust and something older, something that reminded Kai of libraries and attics and places kept secret.

"I'm serious. It's creepy."

The cat's eyes narrowed slightly, which Kai had learned over thirteen years meant either "I'm plotting something" or "you're being ridiculous," and sometimes both.

Kai's bedroom was just big enough for a bed and dresser, but comfortable, with walls painted a soft blue that his mom called "peaceful" and he called "fine, I guess." Posters of his favorite basketball players competed for space with a detailed star chart he printed from the library computer. His desk hid under several notebooks, mechanical pencils, and a half-finished model of the solar system that had been "almost done" for three months.

The September afternoon sun slanted through the window, making Ash's fur look silver at the edges. Outside, the sounds of their Toronto neighborhood drifted up—a car alarm chirping, kids yelling about whose turn it was, a streetcar rattling past on Mapleford Street.

"Kai!" His mother's voice carried up the stairs. "Can you come help me with these groceries?"

"Coming!" Kai marked his page—a chapter about how stars form that was more interesting than his actual homework—and stood up.

Ash made a low sound in his throat.

"What?"

The cat's gaze flicked toward the door, then back to Kai, then to the door again.

"Yes, I'm going downstairs. You can survive without me for five minutes."

Another sound, this one distinctly skeptical.

Kai paused with his hand on the doorknob. "Did you just ... judge me?"

Ash yawned, showing far too many pointy teeth.

"Right. I'm losing it. Talking to a cat like he understands me."

He could have sworn Ash rolled his eyes.

The Yusuf apartment sat above a dry cleaner on a busy corner, which meant it always smelled faintly of detergent and pressed clothes. Kai lived here his entire life, just him and his mom and Ash, in a space that somehow felt both too small and exactly right.

His mother stood in the kitchen, surrounded by reusable grocery bags that she clearly overfilled again. Rafia Ibrahim was a small woman, barely taller than Kai, with laugh lines around her eyes and the expression of someone mentally organizing seventeen things at once. Today she wore her weekend clothes—jeans and a loose turquoise tunic—and her dark hair was pulled back in a ponytail under her matching tortoise hijab, which she removed.

"Perfect timing," she said, not looking up. "Can you put the yogurt in the fridge? And the eggs. Carefully. Last time you—"

"That was one time," Kai protested, grabbing the carton. "And technically the bag broke, so it wasn't my fault."

"The bag broke because you were trying to carry six bags at once."

"Efficiency."

"Broken eggs."

Kai grinned and started unloading groceries. This was familiar territory—the comfortable rhythm of small tasks and smaller arguments that made up most of their weekends. His mom worked long hours at the university library during the week, which meant Saturdays were for errands and cooking and cleaning and catching up.

"How's the astronomy reading going?" she asked, as she handed him a bunch of bananas.

"Good. Did you know that star formation requires ... "

"Dense molecular clouds, yes, you told me yesterday." She smiled.
"And the day before."

"Oh."

"It's fine. I like that you're excited about it."

Kai put the bananas in the fruit bowl, next to two browning apples definitely past their prime. A fruit-fly flew up and settled back down on one of the apples. "Mr. Henderson said there might be a field trip to the planetarium in November."

"That's wonderful!"

"If I keep my math grade up."

His mother's expression shifted slightly. "Kai."

"I know, I know. I'm working on it."

"You're brilliant at astronomy and terrible at algebra, which doesn't make any sense because they're basically the same thing."

"They are not the same thing," Kai said, perhaps too quickly.

"Numbers and patterns ... "

"Stars and story," Kai countered. "Completely different."

His mother looked like she wanted to argue, then thought better of it. She handed him a bag of rice instead. "Pantry. Top shelf."

Kai stood on his toes to slide the rice into place. Behind him, he heard the distinctive sound of Ash jumping onto the counter—something he was absolutely not allowed to do—followed by his mother's resigned sigh.

"Ash, down."

The cat did not move.

"Ash."

Still nothing.

"I'm not kidding. You know the rules."

Kai turned around to see Ash sitting directly next to the cutting board, tail swishing slowly, staring at his mother with a bored expression.

"He's doing it on purpose," Kai said.

"Of course he is. He always does." Rafia pointed at the floor. "Down. Now."

Ash stood, stretched slowly, and then—instead of jumping down—walked the entire length of the counter, past the sink, past the dish rack, to the far end by the window. Only then did he hop down, landing with a soft thump.

"Show-off," Rafia muttered.

Kai laughed. "You've got to admit, that was kind of cool."

"It was, kind of." She started folding the empty grocery bags. "That cat understands every word we say."

Something about the way she said it made Kai pause. It wasn't quite a joke. There was something else in her voice—something careful.

"Mom?"

"Hmm?"

"Do you ever think Ash is ... weird?"

She looked up. "Weird how?"

"I don't know. Smart weird. Like, too smart."

His mother was quiet for a moment, her hands still on the bags. Then she smiled, but it didn't quite reach her eyes. "All cats are weird, honey. That's what makes them cats."

"Yeah, but—"

"Can you grab the pasta from that bag? The one by your foot."

The subject change sent a clear message to Kai. He picked up the pasta and said nothing.

His mother cooked chickpea curry and rice for dinner, which she made the way her mother had taught her—with enough spices to make Kai's eyes water in the best possible way, and to make the apartment smell delicious. They ate at the kitchen table just big enough for the two of them, Ash watching from his spot on the windowsill like a furry gargoyle.

"Mrs. Chen asked about you today," his mother said between bites.

"The one from the dry cleaner?"

"No, the one from the bookstore. She said you haven't been in lately."

Kai swallowed. "I've been busy."

"Too busy for books?"

"That's not what I ... okay, fine, I'll stop by tomorrow."

"She's holding something for you. Wouldn't tell me what."

"Really?" Kai perked up. "Did she say what kind of book?"

"She said it was 'interesting.'" His mother's tone suggested she had opinions about Mrs. Chen's definition of interesting. "Which could mean anything from astrophysics to pigeons."

"That was one book, and the pigeon thing was actually kind of interesting—"

"Kai."

"—in a weird way."

They argued about this for a while, comfortably, the way they argued about most things. Rafia thought Kai should read more fiction. Kai thought fiction was fine but facts were better. She said he was missing out on stories. He said the universe was the best story. She said he was going to turn into one of those people who only talked about black holes at parties. He said that sounded like an excellent party.

Ash watched them both with quiet disdain

After dinner, Kai washed dishes while his mother dried them. This was the rule—whoever didn't cook had to clean—and Kai learned years ago that it was easier to just accept it than to negotiate.

"Mom?"

"Mm?"

"When's my birthday again?"

She paused mid-wipe on a plate. "Are you joking?"

"No, I mean, I know it's September. But what day?"

"September 23rd. Same as it's been for, oh, thirteen years." She set the plate down. "Why?"

Kai shrugged, scrubbing at a stubborn bit of rice. "Just wanted to make sure."

"Kai."

"What?"

"You've been acting strange all day."

"No I haven't."

"You asked me when your birthday was. You know when your birthday is."

"I was just checking."

His mother dried her hands on the towel, then turned to face him fully, one eyebrow raised. "Is something wrong?"

"No."

"Are you worried about school? Your grades are fine. Better than fine."

"I know."

"Is someone bothering you?"

"Mom, no. I'm fine."

She studied his face for a long moment, and Kai tried very hard to look normal and fine and not at all like someone who'd been having weird dreams about glowing crystals and voices calling his name from somewhere underground.

Finally, she sighed. "All right. But if something's wrong—"

"I'll tell you. I know."

She kissed the top of his head—something she could still do, but probably not for much longer—and went to finish drying the dishes.

Kai stared down at the soapy water and tried to remember when the dreams had started. A week ago? Two? They weren't exactly nightmares. Nothing scary happened. But they felt heavy, somehow. Important. Like his brain was trying to tell him something but forgot to use words.

Behind him, Ash made a low, rumbling chirp.

Kai glanced over his shoulder. "What?"

The cat's eyes caught the kitchen light and flashed lime for just a second.

"You're being weird too," Kai muttered.

Ash's tail flicked once, then went still.

That night, Kai lay in bed with his star chart on the ceiling above him—glow-in-the-dark stickers he carefully placed when he was nine

and refused to take down because they were *accurate*, thank you very much.

Ash curled up on the pillow next to his head, purring so loudly he sounded like a small motor.

"Do you think," Kai said quietly, "that weird things happen to everyone? Or just some people?"

The purring continued.

"Like, everyone gets weird dreams sometimes, right? That's normal. Brains are weird."

Purr purr purr.

"And sometimes cats act strange. That's normal too. You're a cat. Strange is your job description."

Ash's ear twitched. He kept purring.

"So probably I'm just overthinking it. Mom says I overthink everything. Which I don't think I do, but that might be me overthinking whether I overthink things."

The purring changed pitch slightly.

Kai rolled onto his side, facing the cat. In the dimness, Ash's eyes looked like two emerald points of light.

"I wish you could talk," Kai said. "You'd probably tell me I'm being ridiculous."

Ash stopped purring.

For a moment—just a moment—Kai could have sworn the cat's expression changed. Not in the normal cat way, the usual blank face. This was different. This was Ash looking at him with something that felt distinctly like frustration.

Then the moment passed.

Ash yawned, showing his fangs, and went back to purring.

Kai pulled his blanket up and closed his eyes. Tomorrow he'd go see Mrs. Chen about whatever book she was holding for him. Tomorrow he'd work on his algebra homework and try not to think about dreams that felt too real. Tomorrow would be normal.

He was almost asleep when Ash shifted position, settling against his shoulder with a weight that felt oddly protective.

Soon, something whispered, though Kai was already too deep into sleep to hear it. *Very soon now.*

Kai woke up to sunlight streaming across his face and Ash sitting on his chest, staring down at him with an expression of annoyed impatience.

"Ugh. What time is it?"

Ash lifted one paw and placed it very deliberately on Kai's nose.

"Okay, okay, I'm up." Kai groaned and pushed the cat aside—gently, because Ash had claws and opinions about being pushed—and said "you're worse than an alarm clock."

He stumbled out of bed and into the bathroom, splashed water on his face, and stared at himself in the mirror. Same face as yesterday. Dark hair that never quite laid flat. Brown eyes that his mother said were exactly like his father's, which always made her go quiet for a moment. Skin that was a shade lighter than hers but darker than most of his classmates.

Completely and totally normal, all of it.

He brushed his teeth and tried not to think about his dream, the one with the crystal spinning slowly in a shaft of moonlight while someone called his name. It was getting harder to ignore them. The dreams appeared more often now, more vivid, more *real* somehow.

"Kai!" His mother's voice drifted up from downstairs. "Breakfast!"

"Coming!"

He pulled on jeans and a t-shirt, the one with the faded astronomy pun that made his mother groan—*why did the sun go to school? To get brighter!*—and headed down to the kitchen.

Rafia stood at the stove, already dressed for the day, hijab perfect, looking like someone who'd been awake for hours. The kitchen smelled like paratha, eggs, and his mother's cardamom coffee. Warm and familiar, the smell of morning and safety.

"You're up early," Kai said, sliding into his chair.

"Couldn't sleep." She set a plate in front of him. "Eat. We have to go out today."

"Where?"

"Errands."

"What kind of errands?"

"The boring kind." She poured tea for herself, then added, almost too casually, "And I need to show you something."

Kai paused with his forkload of scrambled eggs halfway to his mouth. "Show me what?"

"Eat first. Then we'll talk."

"Mom."

"Kai."

They stared at each other. Ash, watching from the counter despite the rules, made a sound that might have been a sigh.

"Fine," Kai said. "But this better not be one of those 'we need to talk about your future' conversations. It's Sunday. Those are illegal on Sundays."

"Just eat your breakfast."

But she wouldn't meet his eyes.

After breakfast, his mother disappeared into her bedroom and came back carrying a basketball-sized wooden box that Kai had never seen before. It looked old—really old—with amazing carvings on the lid that made him think of letters in a language he didn't recognize.

She set it on the kitchen table between them.

"What's that?" Kai asked.

"Something your father left for you."

The air went very still.

Kai's father was not someone they talked about often. Not because it was forbidden or painful, but because there simply wasn't much to say. He died when Kai was only five years old. Stopping something terrible, his mother said, though she never went into details of what or how. Kai barely remembered him, and had exactly three photos of him: one at his wedding, one holding baby Kai in the hospital, and one standing in front of a building Kai didn't recognize, against a backdrop of mountains.

In all three photos, his father looked like someone with a secret.

"He left this?" Kai said quietly.

"He left a few things. Instructions. Letters." Rafia's hands rested on top of the box but didn't open it. "He was very specific about when you were supposed to receive them."

"When?"

"Your thirteenth birthday."

"That was three days ago."

"I know." She took a breath. "I should have given this to you then. I was going to. But I kept thinking ... maybe not yet. Maybe one more day. Maybe ... " She stopped herself. "I'm sorry. That wasn't fair to you."

Kai stared at the box. "What's in it?"

"I don't know. He sealed it. Only you can open it."

"How?"

"I don't know that either."

Ash jumped onto the table—against the rules—and sat down next to the box, tail curled around his paws.

Rafia didn't even tell him to get down.

Kai reached out slowly and touched the lid. The box smelled like fresh pine needles. The wood felt warm under his fingers, warmer than it should be. The carvings seemed to shift slightly in the morning light, though that might have been a trick of shadow.

"Dad left this," he said again, testing the words.

"Yes."

"For me specifically."

"Yes."

"And you don't know what's inside."

"No."

"Because it doesn't open for you."

"Yes."

Kai looked up at his mother. She was watching him with an expression he'd never seen before, something that looked almost like fear.

"Mom, what's going on?"

"Open the box, Kai."

"Not until you tell me what's happening."

"I can't. Not until you open it."

"That doesn't make any sense."

"I know."

They stared at each other. Outside, a streetcar rattled past. Someone's dog barked. The world continued being normal.

Ash made a low trill and placed one paw on the box.

"Even the cat thinks I should open it," Kai muttered.

"The cat," his mother said quietly, "is right."

Kai's hands shook slightly as he gripped the edges of the lid. Whatever was about to happen, whatever was inside this box, it felt like standing at the edge of something. Like the moment before you jump off a diving board, when you can still change your mind but you know you won't.

He lifted the lid.

Light poured out.

Actual, beautiful, golden light spilled out of all sides of the box and across the table like liquid sunshine. It was warm and cool at the same time, and it smelled like thunderstorms and cinnamon and something else Kai couldn't name.

"What—" he started, but his voice stuck in his throat.

Inside the box lay a letter, folded once, sealed with something that looked like wax but shimmered. Beneath the letter, nestled in dark velvet, was a crystal no bigger than his thumb. It had five distinct

facets, each one catching the light differently—gold, blue, orange, red, and black. Next to it sat a fist-sized drawstring bag.

The letter rose slowly out of the box, and hovered in the air between them.

Kai's chair scraped backward. "Mom!"

"It's all right," she said, though her voice was tight. "It's supposed to do that."

"Letters don't float!"

"This one does."

The seal on the letter cracked open by itself, and the paper unfolded in midair. Words appeared on the page—not printed, but *forming*, like someone was writing them right now in dark blue ink.

Kai, the letter read. If you're reading this, it means you've turned thirteen, and it's time for you to know the truth.

The handwriting was strong and neat, with a slight rightward slant.

I'm sorry I won't be there to tell you this myself. I'm sorry for many things, actually; a list so long I couldn't fit it in a thousand letters. But mostly I'm sorry that I won't get to see the person you become. Your mother and I hope you're exactly the brilliant and kind child we hoped for.

Kai's eyes burned. He didn't blink.

The truth is this: You are a wizard, Kai. So was I. So is your mother. Magic is real, and it runs through our blood like a second heartbeat. You have always had it. You have always been capable of things that others would call impossible.

The words hung there, impossible and absolute.

I know this is hard to believe. I know you're probably looking at your mother right now, for explanations. She has them. She kept you safe for thirteen years, hidden from people who would use you or hurt you, and I will love her forever for that strength.

Kai did look at his mother. She was crying silently, tears running down her face.

The crystal in this box is a piece of something much larger, something called the Fivefold Crystal. It's kept at a school, a place where young wizards learn to understand and use their magic. The school is called the Crescent Academy. In exactly one week, someone will come to bring you there.

You don't have to go. Magic or not, you are your own person. You get to choose your path. But if you do go—and I hope you will—know that I am proud of you. I have always been proud of you. Even though I never really got the chance to know you, I knew you would be extraordinary.

There is more to tell you, more than I can put in a letter. Some of it you'll learn at the Academy. Some of it ... well. Some of it I hope you never need to know.

Be brave, Kai. Be curious. Be kind. And trust your instincts, especially when it comes to that cat. He's smarter than he looks.

With all my love,

Asad Yusuf,

Your father.

The letter folded itself back up and settled gently on the table.

Kai couldn't move. Couldn't speak. His entire understanding of reality turned upside-down.

"Mom," he finally managed.

She wiped her eyes. "I know you have questions."

"Questions?" Kai's voice cracked. "I have—I have so many questions I don't even know where to start!"

"I know."

"Magic is real."

"Yes."

"*Magic.*"

"Yes."

"And you're a wizard."

"Yes."

"And I'm a wizard."

"Yes."

"And you never told me!"

"I couldn't." Rafia stood up, came around the table, and knelt in front of his chair. "Kai, listen to me. It was for your own good. There are rules. Laws. Magic isn't just fun and games. It's dangerous. There are people who would hurt children—hurt *you*, specifically—to get what they want. Your father died protecting you from something like that. And I promised him—I *promised*—that I would keep you safe until you were

old enough to understand." She sighed. "It hasn't always been easy. I gave up my connection to the magical world, too, to keep you safe. And I manage all the cooking and cleaning the old fashioned way ... "

Kai nodded.

"So, thirteen is old enough?"

"Apparently that's when it usually appears strongly enough that hiding it becomes harder than teaching it."

Kai's mind was racing. "The dreams. The weird feelings. Ash acting strange ... "

"All signs," his mother confirmed. "I've been watching for them. That's why I knew it was time."

"Ash is magic too?"

On the table, the cat's eyes gleamed.

"Ash is a familiar," Rafia said, "a guardian of sorts, bonded to you since birth. He's been protecting you your whole life."

Kai looked at the cat. Ash looked back, and slow-blinked at him. Something passed between him and the cat, like a flicker of light. And for the first time in thirteen years, Kai *knew*—really knew—what that look meant.

"Finally, Ash said. His voice sounded deep, adult. "Took you long enough."

Kai's jaw dropped. "Oh my god," Kai whispered. "You can talk. You can understand me. You've always understood me."

The cat's tail swished once in confirmation.

"All those times I talked to you ... "

"Every single time."

"And you just let me ramble ... !"

"It was funny."

Kai's head spun.

"This is insane," he said.

"I know," his mother agreed.

"Magic school. Wizards. Familiars. This is ... "

"Completely real."

"Do I have to go?"

She pulled back, surprised. "You don't want to?"

"I—" Kai stopped. Did he want to? "I don't know. This is a lot. An hour ago I was worried about algebra homework."

"You still have to do your homework," his mother said, a smile tugging at her lips despite the tears. "Magic or not, education is important."

"Mom."

"What? It's true."

Kai looked down at the crystal in the box. This close, he could see tiny currents of light moving through it, like miniature rivers. It was beautiful. It was impossible.

It was his.

"What happens if I go?" he asked quietly.

"You learn. You grow. You discover abilities you didn't know you had."

"And if I don't?"

"Then we stay here. I will teach you what I can. And we live a quiet life."

"What do you want me to do?"

Rafia cupped his face in her hands. "I want you to be happy, Kai. That's all I've ever wanted. If the Academy will make you happy, go. If it won't, stay. There's no wrong choice here."

Kai thought about his small room, his small school, his small life. He thought about stars and charts and questions that no one could answer. He thought about feeling like there was something more out there, just beyond reach.

He thought about his father's letter: Be brave. Be curious. Be kind.

"Okay," he heard himself say. "Okay. I'll go."

His mother's smile was worth all the confusion of the last hour.

"I leave in a week, right?" Kai asked.

"Yes. One week. Someone from the Academy will come to escort you."

"What do I need to bring?"

"Not much. They'll provide most things. Clothes, books, supplies." She picked up the drawstring bag and handed it to Kai. It smelled like metal, and felt heavier than he expected.

"You'll need this to pay for some of your stuff. Open it," she said. He pulled it open, and spilled out the contents on the table. Gold coins rolled out.

Kai picked one up and looked at it closely. Thin, solid, it featured an eight-pointed star-shaped hole in the middle. Words in a flowing, Arabic-like script circled the coin.

"Magical money?" he asked.

"Wizard money," she corrected. "Most wizard stores only accept it, because paper money is ... well ... paper." Kai frowned at her, but she shrugged.

He shook his head, plucked the coins from the table, and placed them back in the bag. He pulled it close.

"Can Ash come with me to the Academy?"

Both of them looked at the cat.

"Obviously," Ash said. "Where you go, I go. That's literally my job."

"Familiars always accompany their wizards," Rafia confirmed.

Kai picked up the small crystal, turning it in the morning light. Each facet showed colours that moved and shifted in a different way, as if they were alive.

"Mom?" he said. "What class or house or whatever was Dad in?"

She went very still. "How do you know about the houses?"

He shrugged. "The letter mentioned the Fivefold Crystal. Five facets. I'm guessing five ... houses?"

"You are your father's son." She touched the crystal gently. "He was in House Qamar."

"What does that mean?"

"It means he sought out darkness so others wouldn't have to face it. He was brave and stubborn and absolutely refused to let evil hide."

Kai held the crystal up to the light. The facet that gleamed gold seemed to pulse slightly in his palm.

"What house do you think I'll be in?" he asked.

His mother smiled, sad and proud at the same time. "I think you'll be exactly where you need to be."

They sat there for a while, mother and son and familiar, while the morning light streamed through the window and the world rearranged itself around a truth that waited thirteen years to be spoken.

"So," Kai said eventually, still staring at the crystal, "what happens now?"

"Now?" Rafia stood up, brushing off her jeans. "Now we have a week to prepare you for the Academy. And trust me, there's a lot to cover."

"Like what?"

"Like basic magical theory. Proper familiar etiquette. How to pack for a school you've never seen. Oh, and we should probably tell Mrs. Chen."

Kai blinked. "Mrs. Chen knows about magic?"

"Mrs. Chen is a retired professor of Magical Literature. Why do you think she always has such interesting books?"

"I—" Kai shook his head. "Okay. Sure. Why not. Is everyone I know secretly magical?"

"Not everyone. Mr. Henderson definitely isn't."

"How can you tell?"

"Because a magical person would never assign that much algebra homework without feeling bad."

Despite everything, Kai laughed. It felt good, normal, like maybe the world hadn't completely tilted off its axis.

Ash jumped down from the table and wound himself around Kai's ankles, purring.

"You know," Kai said, looking down at him, "you could have told me about all this sooner."

The purring stopped abruptly.

"Yeah, I know, you couldn't actually talk to me before. But you could have, I don't know, been more obvious about the magic thing."

"I knocked books off your shelf in alphabetical order. What more did you want?"

"Wait, that was on purpose?"

"Obviously. Do you think I'm some kind of idiot?"

Rafia watched this exchange with barely concealed amusement. "He's right, you know. Ash has been trying to signal you for months."

"Months?!"

"Since about March. That's when your magic started becoming noticeable. Little things—electronics behaving oddly around you, that thunderstorm that started the instant you got angry at Marcus Chen for stealing your lunch."

"That was magic?"

"That was magic."

Kai thought back to the spring. There had been a lot of weird coincidences, now that he considered it. Things falling at convenient moments. His mom's car starting after weeks of trouble, right after he touched the hood. That lost library book appearing in his backpack the day before it was due.

"So I've been doing magic accidentally this whole time?"

"Uncontrolled magic, yes. It happens to all young wizards around puberty. Another reason why thirteen is the age to begin training—before you accidentally turn someone into a toad during an argument."

"That's a thing that can happen?"

"With enough anger and insufficient training, yes."

"Okay, slightly terrifying."

"Magic is slightly terrifying," Rafia said seriously. "That's why we teach it. Power without understanding is dangerous, Kai. Your father understood that."

The mention of his father brought them back to the letter, still folded on the table. Kai picked it up carefully, feeling the weight of it.

"Can I keep this?" he asked quietly.

"Of course. It's yours."

He tucked it into his pocket, next to the small crystal. Both felt warm against his leg, like tiny heartbeats.

"Mom? What happened to him? Really?"

Rafia was quiet for a long moment. When she spoke, her voice was steady but sad. "Your father faced something dark. Something that should have been sealed away but wasn't. He stopped it, but ... " She trailed off. "He made sure it couldn't hurt anyone else. Especially you."

"Because I'm his son?"

"Not just that. Because you were important somehow. I don't know the details—your father kept them from me to keep me safe—but I know he died making sure you could grow up free."

Kai absorbed this. His father, a hero. His father, fighting something evil. It should have felt like a story, something distant and unreal, but instead it felt close. Immediate. Like a responsibility settling onto his shoulders.

"Is that thing still out there? The thing he fought?"

"I don't know." His mother looked worried now. "The Academy will have more information. But Kai, listen to me—you are not your father. You don't have to be him. You don't have to fight anything. You're allowed to just be a student who learns magic and has adventures and worries about normal thirteen-year-old things."

"Like algebra?"

"Like algebra."

"But what if—"

"No." She was firm now. "No 'what ifs.' Not today. Today you just found out magic is real. That's enough for one morning. But we do need to cover the basics—what to pack, how the Academy works, what the houses mean. Next week you'll go to the Academy. And whatever comes after that, we'll handle it when we get there. Together."

"Together," Kai repeated. It sounded good. Solid.

Ash meowed loudly, as if to say, "And me! Don't forget me!"

"Together," Kai amended, looking down at the cat. "All three of us."

His mother pulled him into a tight hug. "I'm so proud of you," she whispered. "And your father would be too."

Kai hugged her back, blinking away tears he didn't want to explain. Everything was different now. Everything had changed. But somehow, standing in their small kitchen with his mom and his cat—his familiar—it also felt exactly right.

Like this was always where he was supposed to end up.

Like magic had just been waiting for him to be ready.

When they finally pulled apart, Rafia wiped her eyes and took a shaky breath. "Right. Okay. We should probably eat something. Enormous life revelations require sustenance."

"Pretty sure we already had breakfast."

"That was pre-magic breakfast. This calls for post-magic snacks."

"Is that a magical tradition?"

"It's a mom tradition, which is older and more important."

She bustled around the kitchen, pulling out biscuits and jam, while Kai sat at the table with the wooden box in front of him. The crystal caught the light in a way that seemed almost alive, and he found himself staring into its depths, trying to see what secrets it held.

"Stop that," Ash said. "You'll go cross-eyed."

"Can everyone at the Academy talk to their familiars?" Kai asked.

"If they have one," his mother said, setting down a plate. "Not every wizard bonds with a creature. It's special when it happens."

"How did you know Ash was mine?"

"He showed up on our doorstep the day you were born. Just walked in like he owned the place and curled up in your crib. I tried to remove him three times. He came back three times. Eventually I got the hint."

Kai looked at Ash with new appreciation. "You've been here my whole life."

"Where else would I be?"

"This is so weird."

"You're telling me. I've been waiting thirteen years to have a proper conversation."

"What do you want to talk about?"

"That astronomy book you're reading is wrong about how stars form. There's a magical component they don't teach in regular science."

"Wait, really?"

"Ash," his mother interrupted gently, "maybe save the magical astronomy lesson for later. We have a lot of practical things to cover first."

"Like what?" Kai asked.

"Like what to pack. How to behave at the Academy. What the houses mean. How the Fivefold Crystal works during the Sorting."

"Sorting?"

"That's what they call it when the Crystal determines your house. Every student goes through it at the start of their first year."

"How does it work?"

"The Crystal shows you something. A vision, a possible future. Then it places you in the house where you'll thrive."

"There are five houses," she continued. "Qamar, where your father had been. Ilm, the researchers. Bina, the builders. Taneen, the dragon riders. And Samt, the shadow walkers."

"Dragon riders? Shadow walkers? Awesome!" Kai said. "Wait, what if it puts me in the wrong house?"

"The crystal doesn't make mistakes. It sees who you are, not who you think you should be."

"That's not worrying at all."

His mother smiled. "Magic is rarely comfortable, Kai. But it's always honest."

They spent the rest of the morning at the kitchen table, Rafia pulling out old textbooks with cracked spines and faded covers.

"This was mine," she said, opening one to a page showing a diagram of a five-pointed crystal. "First year theory. You'll hate it."

"Why?"

"Because it's boring. But necessary." She flipped the page. "This is what you'll see on your first day, the Fivefold Crystal. It's massive. Takes up an entire hall."

"And it just ... tells you which house you're in?"

"Not tells. Shows. It reveals something about you—something true—and based on how you react, it places you."

She showed him pictures of the Academy, a crescent-shaped mountain range that looked like something from a dream. She explained about magical creatures and spell theory.

"Wait," Kai interrupted, "do I get a wand?"

She smiled. "We don't use wands often," she said. "We use focused intention—thinking hard about what we want—and, sometimes, tools specific to our house. But mostly just ourselves."

"Oh. So, I don't get a wand?"

"You get something better. You get training in how to channel magic through your own body, your own will."

"That sounds harder."

"It is. But it's also more powerful."

By lunchtime, Kai's head was spinning with information. Magic existed. He was magical. In one week he would live at a school he never heard of, learning abilities he didn't know he had, surrounded by people who

grew up knowing about the world of magic while he'd been worried about math homework.

It should have been terrifying. Instead, it felt like coming home.

That afternoon, as his mother went to make phone calls. "There are protocols," she explained, "paperwork, even in the magical world."

Kai sat on his bed with Ash and the crystal and his father's letter.

"Hey," he said quietly to the cat. "Are you scared?"

"Of what?"

"Change. The Academy. Whatever's out there."

Ash was quiet for a moment. Then: "I was born to protect you. That's not going to change whether we're here or there."

"But what if I mess up? What if I'm not good at magic? What if ... "

"What if you are?"

Kai stopped.

"What if you're exactly as powerful as you're supposed to be? What if you make friends and learn things and have adventures? What if this is the best thing that ever happens to you?"

"You really think that?"

"I know it." Ash's eyes gleamed. "I've known you your whole life, Kai. I know what you're capable of, even if you don't yet."

Kai scratched behind the cat's ears, feeling the rumble of purring.

"Thanks."

“Also, there will be other cats at the Academy. I'm looking forward to judging them.”

"Of course you are."

“Someone has to.”

Kai laughed and lay back on his bed, holding the crystal up to the light. Through it, he could see his room—the familiar walls, the posters, the messy desk—but everything looked slightly different. Sharper. More alive. Like the world had been one way all his life and was now showing him what it actually looked like.

Seven days until the Academy.

Seven days until everything changed.

He couldn't wait.

The preceding was an excerpt of the Shattered Twin. You can purchase the full book, from various vendors, here:

<https://ashiqalibhai.com/books/2026/crescent-academy-1/>